ON TWO SLUICING-LIKE CONSTRUCTIONS IN MUIRA DARGWA[1]

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INTRODUCTION. Sluicing – a term coined by Ross (1969) – refers to an ellipsis construction in which an interrogative clause is reduced to only a *wh*-phrase. A standard analysis of sluicing (Merchant 2001) is that it is movement of a *wh*-phrase to the specifier of the C head, followed by deletion of other material in the clause, which is, to a large degree, isomorphic to its antecedent, see (1a). Some authors (Erteschik-Shir 1977; van Craenenbroeck 2010) have proposed pseudo-sluicing as a possibility, where the ellipsis site is non-isomorphic to its antecedent (1b).

(1) John cooks something, but I don't know what$_i$ Δ.

a. Δ = [$_{TP}$ John cooks t_i] *genuine sluicing*

b. Δ = [$_{TP}$ it is t_i] *pseudo-sluicing*

This view suggests that languages with no left-peripheral *wh*-movement should not exhibit genuine sluicing, instead relying on alternative strategies to derive similar strings. Nakh-Daghestanian languages are known to be among the languages without obligatory *wh*-fronting. Though it is expected that the languages of the family should lack genuine sluicing, no detailed examination has been conducted to assess the validity of this prediction and determine how exactly sluicing-like strings are derived (see Erschler 2021 for some discussion). In this talk, I present data from Muira Dargwa, a Nakh-Daghestanian language, and show that there exist more than one sluicing-like construction (SLC), each derived from a non-isomorphic source.

TWO SOURCES. In Muira Dargwa, reduced embedded interrogative clauses can be of two superficially similar types, as illustrated in (2). The *wh*-remnant of the first SLC exhibits the case-connectivity effect (Merchant 2001), i.e., it must match the case of its correlate in the antecedent clause. The *wh*-remnant of the second SLC, on the other hand, demonstrates the case-disconnectivity effect, being in the absolutive case, irrespective of the case of its correlate.

(2) či-li=jal rasul gap w-arq'-ib, amma nu-ni
who.OBL-ERG=INDEF PN(ABS) praise M-make.PFV-AOR but I-ERG

[{ča=rel / či-li=rel}] ħa-b-alh-a-s
who.ABS=PST+IQ who.OBL-ERG=PST+IQ NEG-N-know.IPFV-TH-1

'Someone praised Rasul, but I don't know who.'

It is uncontroversial that, due to the lack of case-connectivity, the second SLC cannot be considered an instance of genuine sluicing. There is, however, a property that additionally supports this conclusion and provides evidence that the first SLC is also derived differently from the English-type sluicing. As can be seen, the reduced clause contains not only a *wh*-remnant, but also a past tense marker *=ri* and an embedded question marker *=al*. This fact necessitates an analysis different from (1a) for both Muira Dargwa SLCs.

FLAVOURS OF PSEUDO-SLUICING. Though quite similar, the two constructions differ in a number of important respects. First, as demonstrated in (3), when no ellipsis occurs, the *wh*-phrase must match the case of the correlate in the antecedent clause (the verb in the example is in participial form due to the fact that the *wh*-phrase is the focus of the clause, see below).

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(3) <…> [{*ča=rel / či-li=rel} gap w-arq'-ib-il]
who.ABS=PST+IQ who.OBL-ERG=PST+IQ praise M-make.PFV-AOR-ATR

nu-ni ħa-b-alh-a-s
I-ERG NEG-N-know.IPFV-TH-1
'[Someone praised Rasul, but] I do not know who praised Rasul.'

Second, Muira Dargwa permits multiple sluicing, i.e., the case when a reduced embedded question contains more than one remnant *wh*-phrase. Multiple sluicing, crucially, requires that the two *wh*-phrases are case-marked in the same way as their correlates, as illustrated in (4).

(4) či-li=jal si=jal b-iʔ-aˤn, amma nu-ni
who.OBL-ERG=INDEF what.ABS=INDEF N-steal.PFV-AOR but I-ERG

[či-li(=rel) si*(=rel)] ħa-b-alh-u-r=ra
who.OBL-ERG=PST+IQ what(ABS)=PST+IQ NEG-N-know.IPFV-PROG-CVB=1
'Someone stole something, but I don't know who stole what.'

Even more generally, when case-connectivity holds, the remnant can have more material than just the *wh*-phrase, see (5) with the adverb *išħali* 'today'.

(5) sa murad-li musa w-et-ub, [išħali {*ča=rel /
yesterday PN-ERG PN.ABS M-beat.PFV-AOR today who.ABS=PST+IQ

či-li=rel}] nu-ni ħa-b-alh-u-r=ra
who.OBL-ERG=PST+IQ I-ERG NEG-N-know.IPFV-PROG-CVB=1
'Yesterday Murad beat Musa, but I don't know who did it today.'

Finally, an important property of the SLC with the invariably absolutive *wh*-remnant, exemplified in (6), is the "uniqueness" requirement. No such requirement holds for the other SLC.

(6) bašir-li mašina as:-ib, amma [{*ča=jal / či-li=jal}
PN-ERG car(ABS) take.PFV-AOR but who.ABS=IQ who.OBL-ERG=IQ

ʔibri] han ħa-b-irk-u-r=ra
else remember NEG-N-fall.IPFV-PROG-CVB=1
'Bashir bought a car, but I don't remember who else.'

Analysis. Taking all these data into account, I suggest that the properties of the SLC that exhibits no case-connectivity effect are best accounted for by a *pro*-form analysis (Adams & Tomioka 2012; Bai & Takahashi 2023), see (7). According to this analysis, there is no movement or ellipsis involved, but there exists a null E-type pronoun (Evans 1977) that is coreferential with the indefinite DP in the antecedent clause. Note that Muira Dagwa, which is an extensively *pro*-drop language, allows this null pronoun to be phonologically realized (8).

(7) [*pro* ča=COP=IQ]

(8) <…> nu-ni [il ča=rel] ħa-b-alh-a-s
I-ERG this.ADDR(ABS) who.ABS=PST+IQ NEG-N-know.IPFV-TH-1
'[Someone praised Rasul, but] I do not know who it was.'

As for the other SLC, I suggest that clauses *à la* (3) underlie this construction. Namely, what we deal with is a reduced form of an argument-focus construction where a participial clause (*a*P) gets elided leaving the *wh*-phrase as the remnant, see (9). A similar analysis has previously been suggested for Japanese (Hiraiwa and Ishihara 2012) and Uzbek (Gribanova 2013), languages in which remnants in SLCs also exhibit the case-connectivity effect.

(9) [či-li$_i$=COP=IQ ⟨[$_{aP}$ … t_i …]⟩]

OUTLOOK. This work has demonstrated that the two SLCs in Muira Dargwa are derived from two sources – copular clauses and pseudo-clefts, – thus adding evidence to the growing body of research that languages can arrive at sluicing-like strings in multiple different ways (Gribanova 2013). Additionally, Muira Dargwa data provide novel support for a prediction of Merchant's (2001) theory of sluicing, according to which languages with no left-peripheral *wh*-movement should not exhibit genuine sluicing of the English type.

ABBREVIATIONS. 1 – first person; ABS – absolutive; ADDR – addressee; AOR – aorist; ATR – attributive; CVB – converb; ERG – ergative; INDEF – indefinite; IPFV – imperfective; IQ – indirect question; M – masculine; N – neuter; NEG – negation; OBL – oblique; PN – proper name; PFV – perfective; PROG – progressive; PST – past; TH – thematic element.

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